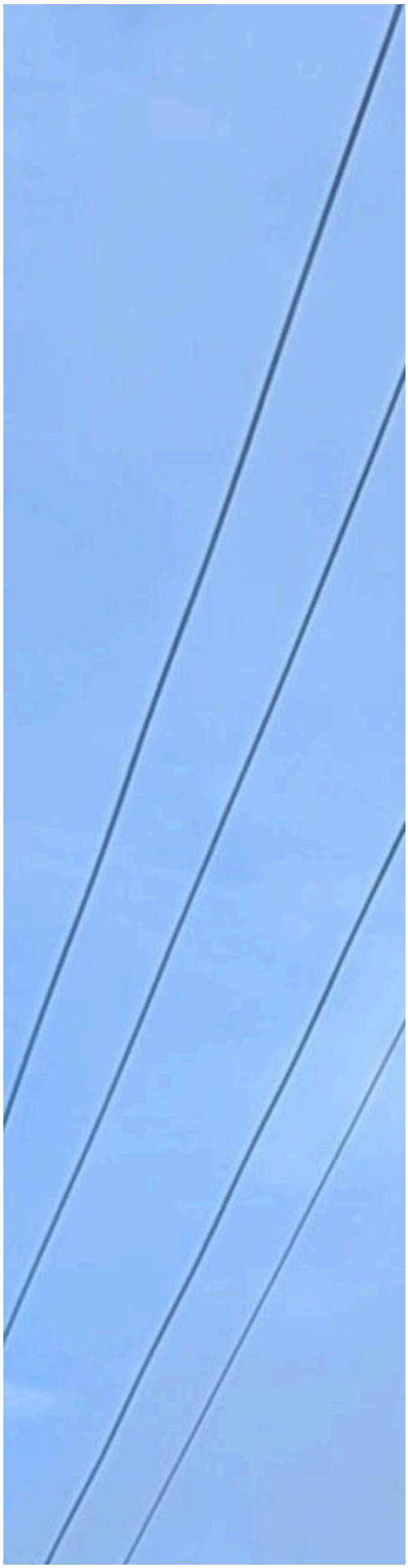
# Brunswick County paying for 8 Flock cameras but have 15 in use — new purchases paused

By **Sophia DePhillips** September 24, 2026



BRUNSWICK COUNTY — Brunswick County commissioners agreed Monday to a 30-day pause on purchasing any new automatec

While ALPRs weren't initially on the agenda for Monday night's meeting, Commissioner Randy Thompson asked the board to con

"We need to have a review done by those that utilize the tool every day in county administration to make sure that we are proper

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Thompson said he brought the motion forward during the commissioners meeting because ALPR's are a hot button topic in the

At two recent meetings a few people spoke.

"Not only do Flock cameras help create a surveillance state, they also present ethical challenges and possible dangers when it c

At Monday's meeting retired law enforcement officer Joe Smith offered a different perspective.

"I am here tonight because I support the responsible use of automated license plate reader technology by law enforcement," Sm

Smith added an individual instance of misuse should not diminish the overall value of the tool.

Chair Mike Forte wasn't against the ALPR cameras but did vote in favor of the policy.

"I proclaim that I am a law-and-order guy, that hasn't changed one bit," Forte said. "I personally don't have a problem with the Fl

Thompson acknowledged people who support it find it a "good tool" for officers while others decry it's a "violation of the Fourth A

Commissioner Pat Sykes cited Fourth Amendment concerns at the two most recent commissioners meetings. She told Port City

Sykes believed the system is vulnerable to misuse and said commissioners have the same authority as the New Hanover County

"Even with audit logs, Flock cannot prevent curiosity lookups, personal tracking, improper misuse, targeting individuals without

## 15 Flock cameras in use — only eight are contracted

The Flock contract with the sheriff's office is for eight automated license plate readers; however, 15 remain in use.

Sheriff's office spokesperson Emily Flax told Port City Daily the technology was initially put on private property with the permiss

However, eventually, the state included a provision to allow the cameras to be on state-owned property. The collaboration betw

Flock was contacted to remove the eight cameras from private property and eight additional cameras were installed on state-o

The work order to remove the seven ALPRs on private property remains in place. Flock nor the sheriff's office responded to Port

The sheriff's office paid Flock $25,620 in November 2025 for the eight cameras it is currently contracted for.

Per the Brunswick County Sheriff's Office's Flock Transparency Portal, in the past 30 days, there have been 380 camera alerts w

These alerts come from hotlists — inventory of license plates officers are looking for — which warn local law enforcement when

The sheriff's office launched its portal at the beginning of September and shared information regarding top offense types, vehic

The employee is being investigated by the State Bureau of Investigation after an internal review audit done by the sheriff's offic

A week later, a Wrightsville Beach police officer was indicted for misusing the county and town's Flock cameras as well.

## $4-million Axon contract

Aside from the sheriff's office contracting with Flock, commissioners also agreed to a $4-million five-year contract with Axon En systems.

Thompson said he learned from the recent discussions over ALPRs that all contracts should be examined more closely. A Noven

"Whenever you send me a 150-page agreement, I'm going to have to go through it with a blooming highlighter and highlight eve

In the November 2025 agenda packet, it included Axon's contract's $4 million, $1.4 million for ALPR cameras — pricing indicated

According to the contract payment summary, the county would have paid $747,820 in October 2025. The next payment is due C

Thompson told Port City Daily the agenda items involving ALPRs typically use verbiage relating to technology and software but

"I don't want to say that the agreements or the contracts were vague," Thompson said. "I'll just say that they've left a lot for inte

At the meeting Sykes also questioned if a recent purchase order for Airship AI — a surveillance, sensor, and data management c

The Airship AI website describes the software as giving customers structured data in real-time as well as at a later date. Real-ti

Commissioners did not vote on the policy, as County Finance Officer Aaron Smith said funds were available in the budget and it

County Spokesperson Meagan Kascsak told Port City Daily the Airship AI purchase order would be used on pole-mounted camer

The county was unable to answer Port City Daily's question by press on how much the purchase order was for.

Thompson would like more time to review the technology and its uses before committing to changing the contract. He said the

New Hanover County commissioners decided on Sept. 8 to cancel the county's ALPR contract with Flock. Twenty ALPRs were ta

"It puts a lot of pressure on your elected body, primarily because of the action that your counterparts in another county," he saic

Thompson hopes the purchasing pause and creation of a committee will act as an educational process for county decision-mak

"I think this goes for building public trust, addressing civil liberties and understanding better the whole county-wide operation,"

He said he would like to see the committee formed and the format outlined in the next week, but did not give a further timeline f

Commissioner Marty Cooke also voted in favor of the motion, questioned initiating another committee: "We're coming up with a

While Sheriff Brian Chism was not at Monday's meeting, he did provide a statement to Port City Daily saying the sheriff's office a

"We welcome the opportunity to work with the commissioners and provide whatever information or assistance they need to bet

Cooke, Forte and Williams did not respond to Port City Daily's request for an interview.

Have tips or comments for Sophia DePhillips? Email sophia@localdailymedia.com

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